

Asian elephant

Elephas maximus

long, flexible trunk
used like a fifth limb



Asia's largest land mammal, the Asian elephant spends most of the day eating up to 330 lb (150 kg) of plant material, including grass and fruit. It also eats cultivated crops such as bananas, causing conflict with humans. About 20 percent of the world's human population lives either in or near the Asian elephant's habitat, forcing these animals into increasingly fragmented areas. Poaching is also a threat, although, unlike African elephants, only male Asian elephants grow tusks, and some males lack them altogether. Females and some

males grow "tushes"—small tusks that rarely extend beyond their mouths. Asian elephants also differ from African elephants in that they have arched backs, double-domed heads, and smaller ears.

Males leave their birth group when they are six or seven years old, living alone or in loose groups with other bulls. Females stay with their families, headed by a matriarch, who leads the herd to water and browsing areas. Females stay bonded to family members for life, using their trunks to greet and caress each other.

◀ HEAVY DRINKERS

Adult Asian elephants need to drink 18–24 gallons (70–90 liters) of water daily, spraying it into their mouth with their trunk.

▷ MALES AT PLAY

Young elephants, particularly bull calves, spend much of their time at play, often charging, sparring, or trunk-wrestling with one another.



↔ 7–12 ft (2–3.6 m)

⚖ Up to 5.5 tons (5 metric tons)

⊗ Endangered

🌿 Grass, fruit, bark, roots



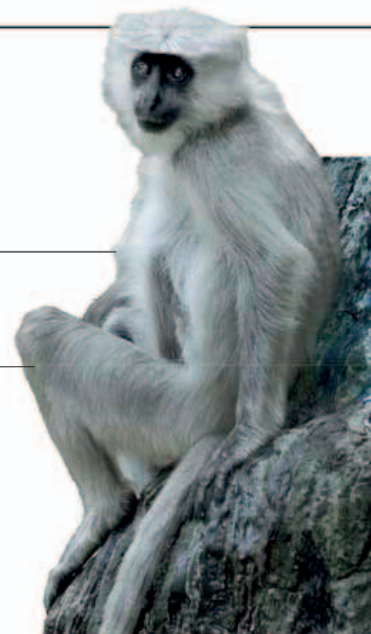
S. and SE. Asia

Terai sacred langur

Semnopithecus hector

Like other species of langur and the related leaf monkeys, the Terai sacred langur (also called the Hanuman langur) feeds mainly on leaves. Its large stomach is separated into two chambers: an upper one, where the leaves are fermented by bacteria, and a lower acidic chamber. This system, like that found in cows and sheep, helps to break down the tough cellulose found in leaves. Because leaves are low in nutrients, langurs have to spend much of their day feeding in trees. However, they can eat many types of leaves and fruit that would be toxic to other species.

long,
slender
limbs



▷ BLACK FACE

According to Hindu mythology, the langur's face was scorched as punishment for stealing a mango.

↔ 23–30 in (58–76 cm)

⚖ 37–38½ lb (17–17.5 kg)

⊗ Near threatened

🌿 Leaves, fruit, flowers, shoots



S. Asia